

US VISA INTERVIEW PREP

1. Why are you here?

I am here for my F1 visa interview that will allow me to pursue my Bachelors degree in International Studies and Economics at the University of Pennsylvania where I have gained admissions into the Huntsman Program. There, I seek to have a concentration in public policies in East African countries to acquire a more refined comprehension of how government policies affect the plight of its citizens.

1. Where are you going?

I am going to the University of Pennsylvania located at the heart of Philadelphia in Pennsylvania State. There I shall pursue my dual degree in Economics and International Studies in the Huntsman program for the consequent 4 years.

2. Why USA?

As my concentration is mainly research based, University of Pennsylvania is well-equipped to walk with me throughout this entire journey especially through its team of seasoned professors from the Wharton School who have already done previous research on such. I will be collaborating and taking part in the creation of knowledge and not just consuming it.

3. Why not your country?

As much as my country has phenomenal institutions, I am limited in my options here as I wish to pursue a dual degree, an aspect that is exclusive of the Huntsman program of the University of Pennsylvania.

Furthermore, the research opportunities here on public policies geared towards addressing generational poverty are quite limited and I wish to heavily venture into this space of research. I shall therefore make the absolute most of my tenure at the University of Pennsylvania.

Secondly, the liberal approach to education offered at the University of Pennsylvania enables me to benefit from a diverse and multicultural student body from all over the world. Such an experience will be truly enriching for me.

4. Why the University of Pennsylvania and not any other?

I have a particular bias towards the University of Pennsylvania as it is the only university that offers a dual degree program in International studies and Economics coupled with a liberal arts education with a heavy accentuation on Foreign languages. For my case, that will be French.

Secondly, the university has superb research opportunities that will enable me to engage in constructive research on how effective government policies can curtail generational poverty, during my summer breaks.

Thirdly, University of Pennsylvania's interdisciplinary approach to learning is unrivaled. There, I shall be a student of two faculties concurrently: Wharton School of Business and The College of Arts and Sciences therefore honing my skills in both faculties.

5. How did you learn about this university?

I knew that I had singularized interests in International Studies and Economics and I was desperately looking for a program that would effectively embrace the two and through the aid of a Lead Mentor at Education USA, I was able to settle for the Huntsman Program of the University of Pennsylvania.

6. What is your study plan?

7. Tell me about your academic background.

I finished high school in December, 2022 at Starehe Boys' Centre and School. From then on, I enrolled at Alliance Francaise de Nairobi, an institution that offers an immersion in the French language and culture. I have been there since March 11 2023, and I shall conclude my studies there on 22nd June after reaching the highest possible level in French classes offered.

8. What have you been doing since you graduated in 2022?

Since my graduation at Starehe Boys' Centre and School, I have been in an intense French immersion program at Alliance Francaise of Nairobi where I have effectively completed all the course requirements with stellar results.

I have also volunteered in various programs as a Lead Mentor. One of them being the IDEA Scholars Program of the Starehe Boys' Centre where we guide scholars on the intricacies of the college admissions process. That is my way of giving back to the community.

9. What will you be doing after your graduation/ What is your career path?

By May 28th 2028, I will have effectively completed my dual degree in the Huntsman program of the University of Pennsylvania. Having taken advantage of the research and the business incubator opportunities, I will have already started a non-profit that is geared towards intensive research on how best government policies can be aligned towards combating generational poverty based on a per country case. By June 2028, I see myself back in the country with not only the resources but also the knowledge that will ensure that my dream of starting this non-profit in Kenya becomes a reality.

10. If offered an opportunity to work in the USA following your graduation, will you take it?

No I will not, as my career goal is linked back to my home country Kenya. I shall refuse the offer for two reasons: I wish to come back to my country to create employment through my non-profit. Secondly, I am the last born in my family and I wish to not only be present but also take care of my elderly parents and reconnect with them as school will have already taken up to four years.

11. Did you get accepted into all the universities you applied to?

Yes because the University of Pennsylvania was the only university I applied to and that was during the Early Decision cycle and I settled for the University of Pennsylvania as they gave me full financial aid with little family contribution.

12. What will you do in the instance of a visa rejection?

While I am confident that my visa will not be rejected, I will respect the decision of the consulate and take time to understand the reason for my rejection. Upon rectifying the issue, I shall reschedule for another interview as studying in the Huntsman program perfectly aligns with my career ambitions.

13. Where are you going to reside?

I shall reside on-campus as it is a requirement by the university that all freshmen reside in campus housing. I am confident that that will be the case for all my four years.

14. Did you take any test scores?

Yes I did sit for my SAT's on the 26th of August, 2023 where I got a 710 in English and a 710 in Math.

15. Do you plan on working while you are studying?

No, I do not plan on taking up employment while studying as my sole purpose in the United States is strictly academic. I also wish to highlight that Penn offers opportunities for the current students to serve as interns and academic tutors. I shall consider this possibility to supplement my income.

16. For how long will you be in the USA?

My stay in the USA is scheduled to begin on the 27th of August 2024 and shall come to an end on the 28th of May 2028 after my scheduled graduation.

17. Tell us the names of the professors you are in contact with.

Erika James, the dean of the Wharton School of Business.

Kelly Cleary, the administrative director of the Huntsman program.

18. Why the Huntsman Program and not any other?

The Huntsman program is the only academic program that is finetuned with my career ambitions as they not only offer a liberal arts education but also a dual-degree program with a focus on leadership and language. Thanks to the Huntsman program, I will not only be a global leader who is culturally aware with a dual degree and fluent in French as a foreign language but also a global citizen striving towards sustainable change.

19. Why should I approve your visa?

I am a scholar who is self-driven, ambitious and passionate about all that he does. With a visa approval, I will have the chance to transform my community and be an agent for positive action in my society. I want change, I truly do and I am cognizant of the fact that someone must be the light bearer and bring the change we all seek. Through my Huntsman education, I shall be empowered to be that light-bearer. So approving my visa is opening a door for growth not only for me as a holistic individual, but also for my community and country at large.

20. Do you have a friend or relative in the US?

At the moment, I do not have any close friends nor close relatives in the US as this is my first time there.

21. What are your future career goals after finishing your program?

22. Who will finance your education and why?

My education at the University of Pennsylvania will be funded by the University itself through grant funding covering my tuition, housing, food, transport, medical cover among other living expenses.

Secondly, one of Penn's policies is Parent contribution. As a result, my father shall support 3% of my education through his income. I have supporting documents for the same starting from an affidavit of support to bank statements starting from December to March this year that validate his capacity to fund the 3%.

23. How did you secure this scholarship?

I secured this need-based scholarship by showcasing a robust academic background with a stellar co-curricular portfolio that merited me into getting admissions with full financial aid covering my tuition, living expenses, housing, food, study abroad, medical insurance and transport.

24. Considering the current economic situation in the USA, why do you want to go there?

I acknowledge that there are some shifts in the US job market currently; however, I wish to highlight that as a student, I shall not be heavily affected by such shifts as my goal there is academic and not economic.

25. Most applicants eventually end up as potential migrants, what assurance do I have that you will not go down the same path and that you will return to your country?

26. How many credits do you require to graduate?
At least 40 course units and I have the extension of taking up to 44 course units.

27. How did you apply?
I filled a common application,
did my essays,
did my interviews
got my supporting documents from school
created a student portal after my application went through

I only applied to the huntsman program Early Decision cycle and got accepted into the University of Pennsylvania.

My expenses will be catered for by Penn as I am a highly aided student on full financial aid. There is an expected financial contribution of 1713 dollars which I have supporting documents for.

How did I get my financial aid?
I filled the CSS profile and attached my family's financial documents from tax forms to income statements.

Which professor

I am in a dual degree program majoring in Economics and International studies.

Why the us...diversity, exposure, multiculturalism,

only school approved internships.

with the resources of a large research university....upenn will further prepare me in a career in.....through.....study abroad...access to the best professors the world has ever seen...exposure to multicultural individuals.

community initiatives....taught in this and that primary school...went back to Starehe to volunteer as a...